

TPB explains charitable donation intentions well; Integrated Behavioral Model use is scarce, and brand links are mostly indirect.

1. Introduction

The literature on charitable donations is dominated by the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB), with the Theory of Reasoned Action (TRA) mainly serving as its precursor and the Integrated Behavioral Model (IBM, or integrative model of behavioral prediction) appearing far less often in donation-specific studies. The strongest donation-specific synthesis identified 117 samples across 104 studies and found strong support for TPB in predicting intention across blood, organ, time, and money donation, while explaining behavior only moderately well (White et al., 2023). Foundationally, TRA emphasizes attitude and subjective norm, TPB adds perceived behavioral control, and the integrative model retains intention as the immediate antecedent of behavior while explicitly incorporating skills and environmental constraints (White et al., 2023; Fishbein, 2008).

Within charitable giving, the recurring predictors are attitude, subjective norm, perceived behavioral control, moral norm, and past behavior, but their relative importance varies by donation type and context. Several extended TPB studies report that moral norm and past behavior materially improve prediction of donation intention (Linden, 2011; Mittelman & Rojas-Méndez, 2018; Veludo-De-Oliveira et al., 2016). Brand management and brand equity are relevant but separate streams: nonprofit branding studies show that brand image, trust, reputation, and identification affect donation intentions, yet direct integration of donation-focused TPB or IBM with donor-based brand equity remains limited and fragmented (Huang & Ku, 2016; Lee & Kim, 2023; Romero et al., 2023).

Does the theory of planned behavior explain charitable donation intentions better than the integrated behavioral model literature currently does?

Requires at least 5 papers that directly answer your question. Try adjusting your query to find more papers.

FIGURE 1 Consensus on TPB dominance in donation research

The meter should read as a strong yes for TPB's current empirical dominance, not as proof that IBM is inferior in principle. Donation studies overwhelmingly test TPB or extended TPB, whereas the corpus contains IBM mainly as a general framework rather than a directly applied donation model (White et al., 2023; Fishbein, 2008).

2. Methods

This review synthesizes a Deep Search run over more than 170 million research papers indexed in Consensus, drawing from Semantic Scholar, PubMed, and other academic sources. The search process identified 294,380 initial records through the seed query, expanded the corpus with citation crawling and targeted follow-up searches on charitable giving, integrated behavioral models, brand equity, nonprofit branding, and competing theories, then screened 238 high-relevance papers. Of those, 144 passed relevance filtering, and the top 50 most relevant papers were included for full synthesis.

Search Strategy

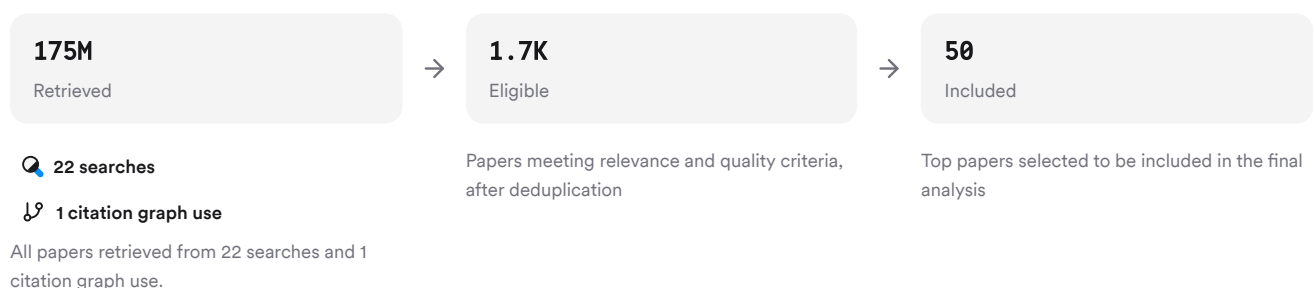


FIGURE 2 Deep search screening and paper inclusion flow

Searches combined foundational theory terms, donation applications, nonprofit branding concepts, and contrasting frameworks to capture both direct and adjacent evidence.

3. Results

3.1 Key Papers

Three papers anchor the corpus for different reasons: the 2023 meta-analysis establishes the donation-specific evidence base for TPB, the 2007 revised TPB study is an early landmark for charitable giving, and the 2020 meta-analysis links TPB to brand equity in consumer behavior rather than donation specifically (White et al., 2023; Smith & McSweeney, 2007; Wu et al., 2020).

Paper	Summary
(Kashif & Run, 2015)	Strong meta-analytic support for donation intention prediction (White et al., 2023)
(Veludo-De-Oliveira et al., 2016)	Early revised TPB model for money giving (Smith & McSweeney, 2007)
(Fishbein, 2008)	Integrates TPB with customer-based brand equity (Wu et al., 2020)

FIGURE 3 Anchor papers for donation and brand literature

3.2 Donation Predictors

TPB predicts charitable donation intention consistently across monetary, time, blood, organ, and online giving contexts (White et al., 2023; Jauhara et al., 2025; Zhou & Xue, 2024). In the largest synthesis, perceived behavioral control had the strongest association with intention, followed closely by moral norm, attitude, and subjective norm (White et al., 2023). Intention was the strongest proximal predictor of later behavior, but behavior variance explained was much lower than intention variance explained, indicating a persistent intention–behavior gap (White et al., 2023).

Dimension	Monetary Giving	Online Giving	Blood/Health Giving	Citations
Core TPB fit	Generally strong	Strong	Strong	(Kashif & Run, 2015; Obadă et al., 2024; Lakew et al., 2026)
Strongest recurring predictors	PBC, moral norm, past behavior	Attitude, PBC, norms	Self-efficacy/PBC, norms	(Mittelman & Rojas-Méndez, 2018; Lee & Kim, 2023; Lakew et al., 2026)
Subjective norm	Mixed	Often relevant	Often relevant	(Mittelman & Rojas-Méndez, 2018; Jauhara et al., 2025; Liu & Han, 2023)
Actual behavior prediction	Moderate	Mediated by intention	Intention often insufficient alone	(White et al., 2023; Jauhara et al., 2025; Lakew et al., 2026)

FIGURE 4 Predictor patterns across donation contexts

Key differences largely concern norms. Subjective norm is non-significant in some monetary-giving studies (Mittelman & Rojas-Méndez, 2018; Pangestu, 2025), but becomes more influential in collectivist, community, or digitally networked settings such as fandom giving, blood donation, and some nonprofit reputation contexts (Liu & Han, 2023; Jauhara et al., 2025; Kim & Han, 2020).

3.3 Model Extensions

The literature rarely uses TRA alone. When compared directly, revised or extended TPB models outperform TRA and standard TPB for charitable donations, largely because they add moral responsibility or past behavior (Veludo-De-Oliveira et al., 2016; Smith & McSweeney, 2007; Li et al., 2024).

Moral norm is the most replicated extension. It was the strongest predictor in one revised TPB study explaining nearly 70% of intention variance (Linden, 2011). It also improved the meta-analytic model from 44% to 52% explained variance in intention (White et al., 2023). Past behavior is similarly robust, predicting intention in Canadian, youth, Muslim, and nonprofit-reputation studies (Mittelman & Rojas-Méndez, 2018; Knowles et al., 2012; Kashif & Run, 2015).

The specific Integrated Behavioral Model is strikingly underused in charitable donation research. The corpus includes IBM as a foundational theory statement rather than as a tested donation model (Fishbein, 2008). Donation scholars instead tend to build ad hoc integrations, most often TPB with norm activation, self-determination, social presence, or trust (Chen et al., 2019; M'Sallem, 2021; Benli & Kocaman, 2025).

3.4 Brand Management and Equity

Direct TPB-to-brand-equity donation models remain rare, but adjacent evidence is substantial. Nonprofit brand image explains a meaningful share of intention to donate money and time, with reported explanatory power up to 31% for money and 24% for time (Michel & Rieunier, 2012). Website-mediated brand image management is also positioned as a route to stronger donation intention, especially through trustworthiness, humanity, and differentiation (Huang & Ku, 2016).

Dimension	Nonprofit Branding Evidence	TPB/Behavioral Relevance	Citations
Brand image	Predicts giving intentions	Likely shapes attitudes	(Huang & Ku, 2016; Michel & Rieunier, 2012)
Trust/reputation	Raises attitudes and intention	Operates alongside TPB beliefs	(Lee & Kim, 2023; Majid et al., 2026)
Identification	Supports intention, especially under reputation strain	Extends normative/self concept pathways	(Kim & Han, 2020; Romero & Abril, 2023)
Brand equity models	Sparse and inconclusive in NGOs	Few direct donation-path tests	(Romero et al., 2023; Romero & Abril, 2023)
TPB-brand integration	Established in consumer markets	Not yet well established for donations	(Wu et al., 2020)

FIGURE 5 Brand constructs adjacent to donation behavior models

The clearest brand-equity evidence comes from outside the donation-specific TPB literature. A meta-analysis in consumer behavior found that brand attitude influences loyalty, loyalty influences brand equity, and brand equity influences behavioral intention, showing that TPB and customer-based brand equity can be integrated meaningfully (Wu et al., 2020). In the nonprofit sector, donor-based brand equity models are emerging, but reviews still describe the field as sparse, inconclusive, and lacking a generally accepted model suited to NGOs (Romero et al., 2023; Romero & Abril, 2023).

Results Timeline

Donation research has moved from early model-building to broader extension and branding-adjacent integration.

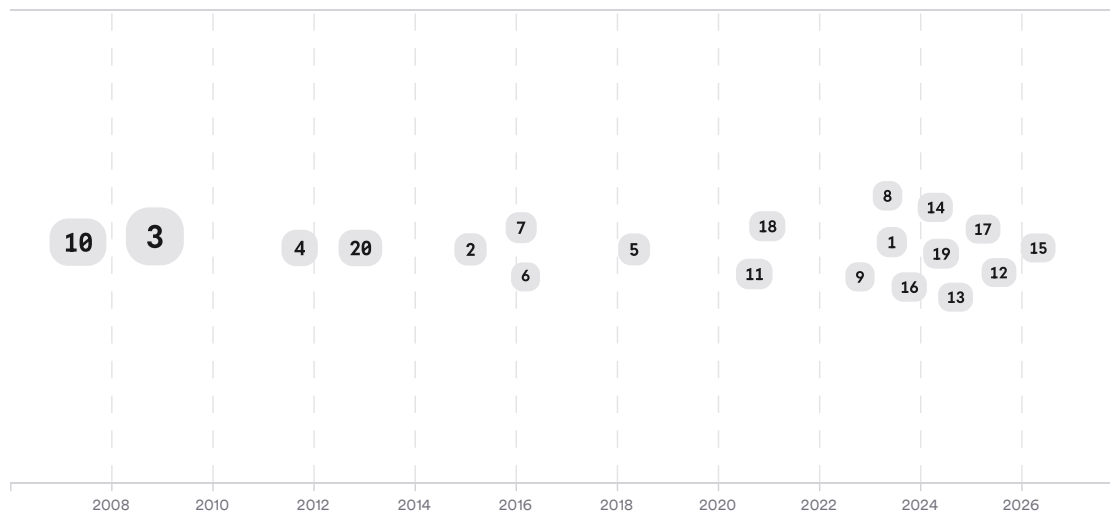


FIGURE 6 Timeline of TPB and donation research arc

The trajectory starts with broad donor-behavior theorizing in the late 1990s, shifts to revised TPB models in the 2000s and 2010s, and more recently adds digital fundraising, reputation, trust, and nonprofit brand constructs (Sargeant, 1999; Smith & McSweeney, 2007; Zhou & Xue, 2024). Larger markers should cluster around foundational TPB and revised TPB work rather than IBM or nonprofit brand equity, reflecting where the literature is densest.

Top Contributors

Based on the included corpus, donation-focused TPB work is most visible around **Muhammad Kashif**, **K. White**, and **M. K. Hyde**, while the most recurrent journals are donation, marketing, and consumer-behavior outlets rather than pure branding journals (Kashif & Run, 2015; White et al., 2023; Knowles et al., 2012).

Type	Name	Papers
Author	Muhammad Kashif	[1f9c88da39415d7abe2a23daddc5cb5c][879223c222cb542ba6c7fa8dbb62f4a6]
Author	K. White	[70427c1f5d3b505c91826bd031ad9829][8f443cb4ed5a5251bb6c01b2625f761c]
Author	M. K. Hyde	[8f443cb4ed5a5251bb6c01b2625f761c]
Journal	<i>PLOS One</i>	[70427c1f5d3b505c91826bd031ad9829][f98d728c40265eaab3ac983c62a0018f] [9ad323b1cb63585889f1ffce80e33686]
Journal	<i>European Journal of Marketing</i>	[2fbd858991e25c0aa06bd1abdb87886d][a3f6c2f9406458fe8055601e13fa48c2]
Journal	<i>Journal of Brand Management</i>	[b86d3089533e51c89ef50ab01e1dda1e][971f944c30365c7db3ca6deb6fed6e3b]

FIGURE 7 Authors and journals appearing most often

4. Discussion

The evidence strongly supports TPB as a useful model of charitable donation intention, especially when the outcome is planned giving rather than observed behavior. The 2023 meta-analysis is the most persuasive study in the corpus because it aggregates 117 samples and shows moderate-to-strong positive associations across the expected pathways (White et al., 2023). Earlier charitable-giving studies converge on the same pattern, which increases confidence that the model is not confined to one geography or donation mode (Smith & McSweeney, 2007; Knowles et al., 2012; Pérez & Egea, 2019).

The main limitation is that TPB explains intention much better than actual behavior. This gap appears in the meta-analysis, in blood donation reviews, and in recent digital-donation studies where intention mediates behavior but does not eliminate contextual friction (White et al., 2023; Lakew et al., 2026; Jauhara et al., 2025). That pattern makes Fishbein's integrative model conceptually relevant because it explicitly recognizes skills and environmental factors as moderators of the intention–behavior relationship, but this theoretical advantage has not yet been translated into a substantial charitable-donation evidence base (Fishbein, 2008).

The corpus also shows why model extensions are so common. Donation is moralized, socially embedded, and often identity-laden, so personal moral obligation, trust, solidarity, religiosity, or organizational reputation often add explanatory value beyond the core TPB triad (Linden, 2011; Lee & Kim, 2023; Majid et al., 2026). At the same time, predictor significance is not stable across all contexts: subjective norms can disappear in some monetary-giving samples, and attitude can even become non-significant when CEO reputation or campaign design dominates evaluation (Mittelman & Rojas-Méndez, 2018; Kim & Han, 2020).

Brand management and brand equity remain the least mature part of this literature. There is credible evidence that nonprofit brand image, trust, reputation, and activism affect donor responses (Michel & Rieunier, 2012; Lee & Kim, 2023; Lee et al., 2023). But the direct bridge from TPB or IBM constructs to donor-based brand equity is still mostly inferential, because nonprofit brand equity models are few, contested, and often measured with organization-specific scales that limit generalization (Romero & Abril, 2023).

Claim	Evidence Strength	Reasoning	Papers
TPB predicts charitable donation intention well across contexts	 Strong	Supported by a large meta-analysis and multiple replications across money, time, blood, and online giving	(White et al., 2023; Jauhara et al., 2025)
Adding moral norm and past behavior usually improves prediction	 Strong	Repeated in revised TPB studies and meta-analytic estimates, though not universal in every sample	(White et al., 2023; Linden, 2011; Veludo-De-Oliveira et al., 2016)
TPB predicts behavior less well than intention	 Moderate	Consistent moderate behavior prediction and repeated intention–behavior gap across donation domains	(White et al., 2023; Lakew et al., 2026)
IBM is directly applied to charitable donations	 Weak	IBM appears in foundational theory papers, but direct donation applications are largely absent in this corpus	(Fishbein, 2008)
TPB has an established direct link to nonprofit brand equity	 Weak	Brand-adjacent constructs are studied, but direct integrated donor-equity models remain sparse and inconclusive	(Romero et al., 2023; Romero & Abril, 2023; Wu et al., 2020)

FIGURE 8 Key claims and evidence strength ratings

5. Conclusion

Across this corpus, TPB is the established behavioral framework for charitable donations, TRA matters mainly historically, and the specific Integrated Behavioral Model remains more conceptual than empirical in this domain. The literature is strongest on predicting intention, moderately strong on model extensions such as moral norm and past behavior, and weakest on directly integrating donation behavior models with nonprofit brand equity.

Research Gaps

The clearest gaps concern IBM application, longitudinal behavior measurement, and unified brand-equity modeling for nonprofits. The field has many TPB studies, but far fewer studies that test environmental constraints, donor capabilities, and branding variables within a single integrated causal model.

Topic/Outcome	Longitudinal behavior	IBM application	Brand equity integration	Cross-cultural comparison
Monetary donation	4	GAP	2	3
Online/social media donation	2	GAP	2	2
Blood/health donation	3	1	GAP	3
Nonprofit brand equity	1	GAP	4	1
Cause-related brand outcomes	1	GAP	3	1

FIGURE 9 Research coverage gaps across donation subtopics

Open Research Questions

The next step is not another generic TPB replication, but integrated designs that test when organizational and environmental conditions convert donor intentions into action.

Question	Why
Do IBM-style environmental constraints and donor skills explain the intention-behavior gap in charitable giving better than extended TPB alone?	This would test the main theoretical advantage IBM claims but donation studies have rarely operationalized.
How do nonprofit brand image, trust, and donor-based brand equity interact with TPB constructs to shape repeated donation behavior?	Current evidence links these streams indirectly, but not in a stable integrated model for nonprofits.
Which donation contexts make subjective norms or moral norms dominant predictors: collectivist cultures, digital communities, or crisis giving?	Norm effects are inconsistent across studies, suggesting meaningful moderation by social setting and platform design.

FIGURE 10 Open questions for future donation research

For charitable donations, the literature supports TPB strongly, supports IBM only indirectly, and leaves the TPB–brand equity connection as an important but still underdeveloped research frontier.

These search results were found and analyzed using Consensus, an AI-powered search engine for research. Try it at <https://consensus.app>. © 2026 Consensus NLP, Inc. Personal, non-commercial use only; redistribution requires copyright holders' consent.

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